We can read into this a transformation into myth of the subduing of the snake-worshipping peoples of the Haryana plain by the advancing Arya. From about 400 BCE onwards these indigenous Naga snake-gods were brought into the Arya fold to become allies and protectors – not only in Brahminical Hinduism, but also in Jainism and Buddhism. To this day, a number of peoples of the Indian subcontinent declare themselves to be Nagavanshi or ‘of Naga descent’, most notably the Nairs and Bunts of Kerala and Tamil Nadu (of whom more in the next chapter) and the Nagavanshi Rajputs of the mountain country of Kalahandi in Odisha.



A bas-relief from a Buddhist stupa excavated at Nagarjunakonda by Arthur Longhurst showing the subduing of a Naga snake-king.